

The Prayer of the Apostle Paul

Codex Reference: I,1

Translated by: Dieter Mueller

Source: Robinson, J.M. (ed.), *The Nag Hammadi Library in English*, 3rd rev. ed. (HarperSanFrancisco, 1990), p. 27ff.

Editor's Introduction

Introduced and translated by Dieter Mueller

The Prayer of the Apostle Paul occupies the front flyleaf of Codex I, also known as the Jung Codex. The scribe apparently added this prayer to the collection of tractates in the codex after he had finished copying The Tripartite Tractate (1,5). The title, followed by a brief colophon, is placed at the end of the prayer. The Greek language retained in that title was no doubt the original language of the prayer as a whole. The short text is of unknown provenance. Its general gnostic affinities are clear. Details such as the reference to the “psychic God” (A,31) may indicate Valentinian connections. That association in turn suggests a date of origin between the second half of the second century and the end of the third century.

In form and content The Prayer of the Apostle Paul echoes various other compositions. It displays a striking resemblance not only to prayers in the Corpus Hermeticum (1.31-32; 5.10-11; 13.16-20) but also to invocations found in magical texts. Furthermore, its beginning is rather similar to that of the hymn of the First Stele of The Three Steles of Seth (VII,5). Both documents may use a common tradition. There are also similarities within The Gospel of Philip (II,3). In general, The Prayer of the Apostle Paul is heavily indebted to the Psalms and the Pauline letters. The most striking echo of the apostle, and at the same time a clear index of gnostic orientation, is the request to be granted “what no angel-eye has seen and no archon-ear has heard and what has not entered into the human heart” (cf. 1 Co 2:9).